Dilawar's controversial rhetoric is nothing new. On October 19, a court in Kota may have acquitted him of charges related to inciting religious sentiments during a 2018 rally, but his hardline Hindutva stance has only bolstered his support within the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS)—the organisation where he cut his teeth on socio-politics before emerging as a prominent Dalit leader in the Kota-Baran region. In February, the six-term MLA, now serving as minister for the third time, called Mughal emperor Akbar a "rapist and tyrant". It was around the same time that he placed under suspension three Muslim schoolteachers, accusing them of encouraging religious conversions. Then, in June, he stoked tensions with Bharat Adivasi Party (BAP) leaders who had claimed that tribals were not Hindus. Dilawar suggested DNA tests to confirm their Hindu heritage, a statement that was quickly met with howls of protests.

Earlier, upon taking office, Dilawar had voiced his opposition to English-medium schools initiated by the previous Congress government, even suggesting that they be shut down. He also ordered teachers to stop carrying mobile phones to schools to avoid getting distracted. A backlash forced the order to be amended. But, as it turns out, Dilawar's unfiltered remarks continue unabated, fuelling one controversy after another. ■

DILAWAR'S DIATRIBE

- **Rajasthan education minister Madan Dilawar has sparked outrage with comments on the attire of women teachers**
- **Earlier, he opposed English-medium schools, suggested DNA tests for tribal leaders, prompting even BJP leaders to call for measured statements**



PEOPLE POWER
Protesters at ousted PM Sheikh Hasina's house in Dhaka, Aug. 5

AFP

BANGLADESH

HISTORY RESET IN DHAKA

By Arkamoy Datta Majumdar

When the interim government led by Nobel laureate Muhammad Yunus took over a violence-stricken Bangladesh on August 8, it promised state reforms. Now, many are questioning its priorities after it recently cancelled eight 'national days' observed by government decree during the ousted Sheikh Hasina regime. While most agree that the former prime minister—daughter of 'Bangabandhu' Sheikh Mujibur Rahman—had attempted to monopolise the 1971 war of liberation that led to the creation of Bangladesh and thus its history, they also say that there are more pressing issues to take care of.

On October 16, it was announced that an advisory committee of the government has cancelled eight holidays that mashed together genuine national moments with family history: the historic March 7 call for independence in 1971 by Mujib, his birth anniversary on March 17, the birth anniversaries of Hasina's deceased brother Shiekh Kamal, her mother Begum Fazilatunnesa and her youngest brother Sheikh Russel on August 5, August 8 and October 18, respectively, Mujib's death anniversary on August 15 and Constitution Day on November 4. Smart Bangladesh Day on Decem-